

Interview Transcript – Participant M

Study: Early Value Challenges for Non-Technical Users of AI Automation Builders

Date: 9 March 2026

Duration: ~30 minutes

Interviewer: J (researcher)

Participant: M (pseudonym)

Participant Role: Independent entrepreneur and SaaS founder with approximately 10 years of experience in the technology sector, including roles in software engineering and product management. Currently self-employed (sole proprietorship) in the Netherlands, building and operating automation-related digital products. Has a technical background but works primarily as a solo founder handling product development, marketing, and customer support.

Anonymization note: All identifying information (name, company names, specific product names) has been removed or replaced with neutral descriptors.

J: Yeah, so do you consent to being part of this study and me recording and with the whole informed consent we went over? Great. Okay, yeah, let me start with the questions. So first I want to have some background about what your responsibilities are on a day-to-day basis, what you do. So can you briefly describe your role and your main day-to-day responsibilities?

M: Yeah, I am an entrepreneur. I've worked in technology for 10 years. I had a full-time job but in 2020, from 2024, I chose to become an entrepreneur. I have a couple of products out there. One is a WhatsApp automation platform which is launched on major automation platforms, and I'm also building another platform which is an automation platform which will go live in the next two, three months. So yeah, that's what I do. Primarily work as an entrepreneur. I am registered as a sole proprietor in the Netherlands.

J: Okay, cool. Yeah, so you already said something about before this, before I start recording, you had some technical background, right?

M: I'm sorry, could you please repeat the question?

J: Oh yeah, so can you describe your technical background? Do you have any experience with programming or building things digitally?

M: Yeah, I worked as a software engineer for four years. Then I worked in product management, so worked in the technology space for more than 10 years. Yes, I come from a programming background. I still do a lot of coding, but with AI assisted now. But yes, technically I would say I am a builder and I like to launch products. I'm also currently a solo founder, which means I do the building, marketing, and as well as customer support for all of my products. That's what takes up most of my time. Yeah, and I would say my scale is what you would say as somebody who just started out as an entrepreneur, not very big, just trying to, you know, being on that path.

J: Yes, okay, clear. Yeah, so what automation tools have you already used and what made you try it in the first place?

M: I think what made me try these automation platforms was initially trying to build some minimum viable products like launching forms, getting user research done. I didn't want to build anything solid before I launch a product, so I was doing a lot of user testing, understanding user feedback by

launching simple landing pages. And these platforms allowed me to launch simple landing pages, collect feedback without having to code a single line. So that's what drove me to explore these platforms. Yeah, and I would say they are fairly good at what they do. But that's what helped me initially to validate a product idea before I build anything.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah, so you already mentioned about you want to validate and that's why you started using it. So what was actually, what were you trying to accomplish specifically when you first use it? What was the task or, yeah, really specific goal?

M: Yeah, I would say it was quite specific initially, not invest too much in engineering. How much, how quickly I can get user feedback, not just getting user feedback. I also launched some dynamic products, which means users can log in and see the flows. So I also build what you call as minimum viable products using no-code tools. Which helped me to not invest a lot in engineering upfront. Otherwise I would have to do the hosting myself, and do a lot of back-end coding, front-end coding. All of this was time saved for me. I could go to the market very quickly. So that was the specific goal with which I tried these platforms.

J: Yeah, very clear. Yeah, so I think this question already, you already went over it. Let me skip that one. Yeah, so I'm now wondering about what challenges you, yeah, you encountered. So if you think back to your very first session with the tool, of any automation tool you used, yeah, can you kind of walk me through what happened step-by-step? Yeah, because I'm especially interested in any moment where something didn't go the way you expected. So yeah, can you walk me through step-by-step?

M: Yeah, I think all the platforms did have certain learning curve. I wouldn't say that it was still easy for me coming even from a technical background. All of them had certain learning curve. I had to understand their own terminology. Everybody, for example, one platform calls them trigger webhook, but another would call them a trigger. So they all had different naming conventions, and different terminologies, and different user interfaces as well. So getting used to them was definitely an initial challenge. But once I got comfortable with them, it would take me like a week or two to understand how those work. And I would watch a couple of YouTube tutorials to know where I'm going wrong. Things don't work for the first time. But slowly, I think in the first one month, I understood how these platforms work. And that helped me to build more and more. But within a month, I think it's also very difficult to understand the capabilities of these platforms. These platforms are very, very powerful. They have a lot of integrations and a lot of things you can do. So there is a lot to learn. I kind of got lost in somewhere at some point. I would explore a lot of things and then come back to the actual goal at hand, because they are so powerful, I tend to deviate. Also, the pricing is difficult to understand. They all have a freemium model, which means very easy to get started. But once I start to use more and more flows, I see that I hit the ceilings for freemium very quickly. For example, one platform had no multi-step flows on the free plan. If you had more than two blocks in a flow, it's not part of the free plan. That means that it will be a problem because we are building something like a dynamic flow. With two blocks, you can't do much. You need more blocks. You need conditional logic. If this happens do something, if this doesn't happen do something else. So those automations would cost me money. And soon I realized that these platforms were expensive. And it was difficult for me to know all of this at the beginning, unless I tried the platform and used it for a few days. And so there were some shocks later on. I think that was one of the problems I faced. But I still continued. I paid for a subscription. And because it was

difficult to move away once I started learning, there was a certain time investment I made. And then I got comfortable with a platform. Then I shipped with it. Now there is a full learning curve again if I switch. So I got reeled in. And then I used it for a couple of months. And I found that it was becoming very expensive for me to maintain for an MVP. Then I started exploring other alternatives. And the whole cycle I had to go through again. I had to again learn the user interface. There were also pricing shocks there. So every platform had, I would say, very easy to start, they are all very powerful. But they had their own kinks on terminologies and close workflows. And there were certain pricing shocks, which I discovered as I started becoming a power user of these platforms.

J: Yeah. OK. So what I'm most interested in is, of course, the first time experience. So the first time you start using it and you already mentioned that there's a learning curve for each new tool that you have to use. And then eventually, once you start getting to know the tools, you start using them, you have pricing shocks. And yeah, you've got issues with it becoming more expensive. So that's not really — it is a challenge that you experience later. But for the first time, it's mostly a learning curve. And what was, where exactly was that learning curve? What did you encounter as challenges, specific challenges for the first time?

M: Yeah, I think the flows had blocks, like how you can drag and drop. They are all drag and drop visualizations. Understanding what each block does itself is a major learning curve. There are like hundreds of blocks they have and thousands of integrations or third party integrations. Each third party integration exposes like what it can do as a capability. So there's so much to digest as information, like, how this block works, what is the input to that block, how it processes, what output will come. And even for me, I understood what a block works because I did work with drag and drop visualizers before. But still, it was a learning curve for me to know what each block means, what input should go, what output will come, and how I sequentially process one block after the other. That was a learning curve. How do you dynamically map output from one block to an input to the other block? That was a learning curve. Failures, errors, the first times when I try to test these blocks, there will be something I will miss and then there will be an error. Trying to debug those errors was a learning curve. Yeah, I think all of these are. I tried to watch tutorials, but they are pretty basic on YouTube. But once I got hands-on and really knew what my use cases were, then I figured out which block is most useful for me to try this and then experimented with a few blocks. Then I fairly got comfortable with 3-4 blocks. And then I started using AI to help me out, understand, if this is the flow I want to build, what is the best block I should use? What should the flow look like? And even today, it will still take me like a couple of hours to build something on these platforms. Because I know the use case, I know what I want to do, but I have to find the right block. I have to set the right inputs, right outputs, tie them up together, set the right scheduling. So all of this still takes me like a couple of hours, but it used to take like a whole day to build one use case. Now it's like two hours. And I feel that maybe it's only the most experts that can bring it down to maybe 30 minutes, but I'm not at that stage.

J: OK, yeah, so yeah, it took a long time before you actually got that early win, that you actually solved the use case with an automation builder.

M: Yeah, I would say, yeah, for somebody who is a non-starter, it would take like a couple of days before you actually see the benefits of, oh, this is my first use case that is live. It took me a whole day to make it live for the first time.

J: Yeah, OK. And just maybe this is useful. How long, do you have more than seven minutes or do you have less than even seven minutes?

M: OK, because I did join late, so I would extend that courtesy to you.

J: OK, great. Yeah, so once you had the automations running, did you feel in control of what was happening or did you feel like you were handing things over without really knowing what was going on? Of course, you build yourself, so I could imagine that maybe in that case you really feel in control.

M: Yeah, I would say, yes, control was never a problem because they had very transparent reporting. I would say when the automations failed, I could check the historical runs, where it failed, why it failed, and there were proper reasoning and errors reported. With another platform, it was a bit tricky. Their reporting was a little bit off, and if something fails, it would fail silently. There was no error report. So, yeah, yes, but still I think once the automation works, because I would test it and then only publish it and then make it live, I was fairly confident they would work. And then I would monitor those use cases because most of some of them are my product flows, see if they are working as expected in the initial days. And so, yes, there was some observations or monitoring once it goes live for the first couple of days. But if first couple of days go well, I don't have to make any changes and I ease it off and sit back and see how it goes.

J: Yeah. So, did you use most of the use cases you did — did you use them really for yourself or did you also build it for clients, for example, or customers?

M: I would say no clients. It was primarily for my personal use case or for my MVPs, my own product use cases, like syncing between different databases or somebody fills a form on my website, I send them an email. So, mostly for my product, not for third-party clients.

J: Yeah. Okay. Yeah. So, when you got stuck with an automation builder, how did you usually try to solve that? Did you go to documentation, for example, or was it trial and error mostly or YouTube tutorials? What was your main thing, how to resolve the problems you encountered when you got stuck?

M: I would say I used a mix of solutions. In the beginning, when I was figuring out, I watched tutorials, I searched their documentation, community forums. But eventually I figured out that the best way was to work with an AI tool, which can extract this information from communities or YouTube tutorials or the documentation faster than I could extract. So, if I report the exact error or problem that I'm facing to an AI assistant, it used to help me out with extracting this information. Initially, I did try this manually, a mix of all of these things. Actually, I tried all. I followed a YouTube channel. I used to search on community forums. And I will do Google search. I will possibly also go through their documentation very extensively. But it was painstakingly manual and used to take a lot of my time.

J: Yeah. Okay. Yeah. So, to go back to the first session again, did you feel like you really accomplished something useful in that first session with the automation platform?

M: I would say they did the job they mentioned. Once you pass the learning curve, which was possibly one week for me, once I got very comfortable, I found myself using it more and more. Once the learning curve has passed, I got fairly comfortable with those platforms to the extent that then I did publish the apps and my own custom apps there so that I could do more automations.

J: Yeah. Okay. And if the tool could have done one thing differently to make the first user experience better, could you think of something that would make it better for the first time user experience?

M: I'm not sure what they could additionally do, but I think these were the problems. If there is something they could do to reduce the learning curve, because I'm not sure. I have used other enterprise products. Generally, all the enterprise products have some learning curve. They possibly could cut down on what I could start with, so it's easy to start. I could think of one good example is possibly a certain email application, which made it quite easy to get onboarded and then get to use it very quickly. So they have a physical video call onboarding process. Somebody explains to you how the application works. Maybe this might be too expensive for platforms which operate on millions of users. But yeah, that could have helped me, but I'm not sure how viable that is.

J: Okay. Yeah. So did this whole experience of trying to automate some use cases, did it also give you ideas of automating other things when you first started? Are you more willing to try automating other things in your work because of it?

M: I would say yes. Yeah, totally. Because I know that I got comfortable now. I know how powerful these tools are that I am able to automate a lot of my manual tasks. So yeah, I actually did automate a lot more things later on, like a lot of messages on messaging apps are now automated because I've set up these automations. I've automated some emails. So yes, using these tools definitely did help me to accommodate automations more in my life, not just in work, but also in personal, I would say.

J: Okay. Yeah. Nice. Let me see if there's anything I can ask. Yeah. I think I already have quite a good view, quite a good picture on what challenges you encountered. And yeah, that's mostly like a very steep learning curve in the beginning. But once you got more comfortable, you started automating more things as well. And the tools were very, yeah, convenient to use, I think. So that's nice. Yeah. So I don't think I have any more questions regarding to the challenges. And maybe you can think of something, maybe something comes to your head now that you might be thinking, that's another challenge I encountered, but otherwise, I don't have any more questions.

M: Yeah. I'm particularly interested in the research angle. You did mention about the adoption problem, and that's what the research is focusing on. These platforms have like a very large active user base. And then what I realized is they are very expensive tools for me as a person to use, as an individual entrepreneur, paying out of pocket, around €50–60 every month was quite expensive. And is your research focused on the subscription fatigue these platforms charge for? Because once I get adopted to this platform, I realize how powerful the automations are, but there are so many subscriptions that add up once I start automating. So one platform is the one that introduces me to automations, but then you like something inside there and say, oh, I can also automate this, but this would charge me a subscription. So there are a lot of apps inside that, which will, again, ask you to use those, you have to pay additional money. They are not covered as part of the base subscription. So they are behind the paywall. The subscriptions quickly added up. And that's what I was saying that there were a lot of pricing shocks later on, not just the primary platform one, but also there are so many third-party applications behind paywall listed there, which costed, to adopt is costing more money for an individual entrepreneur. That I see was the biggest barrier for me that made me a churn user to the free tier. But yeah, I did like the automation and I continued to use more automations, but I just now use the free tools and I didn't want to adopt the paid tools because they

were becoming expensive to pay every month.

J: Yeah, okay. That's very good that you mentioned it, because this is the first interview I'm doing and I already did a literature review, but I did not find this in the literature. So that's a very good new challenge that I can also list in my thesis, I think. And I'm also curious with the following interviews, of course, if other people will mention the same thing. So that's very nice.

M: Yeah, I have a vested interest because that's the problem I'm solving for in my next product. And I would like to know if your research collaborates this problem statement, like the subscription fatigue with respect to automation platforms. There are multiple SaaS subscriptions now and everything for an individual entrepreneur or a small business. I would say enterprises would be happy to pay because they would save so much time and then their businesses would generate so much revenue. But an individual entrepreneur earning a modest monthly income, I'm not sure they're willing to spend a significant portion on subscriptions alone.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah. So yeah, I will keep you updated on the progress of my thesis because I think you're interested in the results. So I'll keep you updated. Do you know any other people that might be interested for me to talk to as well? And maybe you know some more non-technical users, for example, that have tried automation builders.

M: Yes, I know someone who worked with me. He tried automation platforms. I'm not sure which ones exactly, but I know he tried other automation platforms. I can possibly refer him.

J: Would you be willing to introduce me to him, see if he's even interested in talking to me and see if we can be in touch?

M: Yeah, definitely. If you can send me an email with the requirements and the scope of the research. I will introduce you to him and you both can take it off from there.

J: Sure. Very nice. Thank you. Okay. And yeah, I don't have any more questions. I want to thank you very much for your time and your insights. I think it's been very valuable. So that's great. And yeah, I'll keep you updated. I'll send you the email for the other participants and I'll keep you just updated of my progress.

M: Definitely. Thanks for your time as well. And let's be connected on the email then.

J: Yes. All right. Thank you. Have a nice day.

M: Thank you. You too. Bye-bye.

J: Bye-bye.